SOP-IT-002 · Reading room and helper access: browser first, a token only if needed

SOP IT-002 | Status draft | Changed 2026-11-01 | For Members and stewards

Department: IT · **ID:** 002 · **Status:** draft (approved when tagged) · **Owner:** organisation administrator · **Last changed:** 2026-11-01

Purpose

The steps a member follows to read an organisation's private repositories, and the steps for letting an AI helper read the same selected material, with the smallest credential that fits. The reasoning lives in proposal THEF 012 and in `my-template/org-onboarding/ACCESS-AND-PATS.md`; this is only the procedure.

Scope

Any person given access to an organisation's private repositories, and their helper. Not for treasury keys, recovery codes or passwords.

Roles

Role	Does
Member	signs in, reads, asks for a helper if wanted
Administrator	invites, approves token requests, verifies as the member
Helper	reads only what it is granted; never receives a secret in chat

Steps: read as yourself

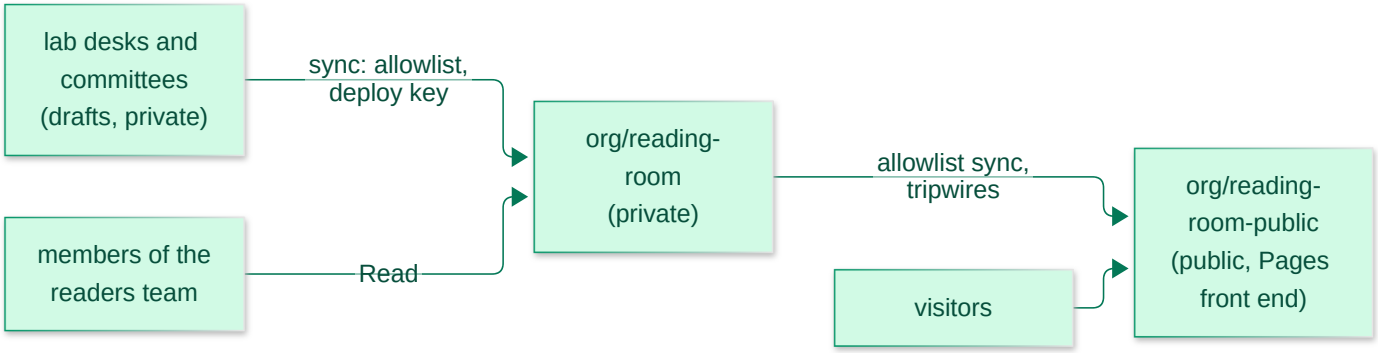
1. Sign in to GitHub with your own account and two-factor authentication on. *You should see:* your avatar top right.
2. Accept the organisation invitation (email or the bell icon). *You should see:* the organisation under your profile's Organizations.
3. Open the repository link you were given, then one README and its PDF under `pdf/`. *You should see:* the page, not a 404. A 404 on a private link means permission is absent: tell the administrator which account you are signed in as.
4. Reply where you already talk to the organisation, or open an Issue if your role allows.

Steps: bring a helper, optionally

1. Ask whether the helper already has an approved GitHub connection that reaches the repository. *If yes:* stop here.
2. If a credential is required, create a **fine-grained personal access token** in your own account: resource owner = the organisation; only the repositories needed; **Contents: Read-only** (plus the metadata GitHub requires); a short expiry. *You should see:* the token once; copy it only into the helper's own credential store.
3. The administrator approves the request if the organisation requires approval. *You should see:* the token's status change from pending to active.
4. Ask the helper to read one named README and summarise it without changing anything. *You should see:* a correct summary and no commit.
5. Record owner, purpose, repositories, expiry and who can revoke, in the organisation's private onboarding notes. Never the token.
6. Revoke or rotate when the purpose ends, the role changes, a device is lost, or exposure is suspected.

The reading-room route (organisation-owned)

A **reading room** is where an organisation's people read drafts that are not public yet, with a public room beside it for what is ready for visitors. Fill in your organisation's addresses once, then link this table from the organisation's `.github` README and its onboarding page.



The sync's rule and the tripwires are in SOP-OPS-003; the readers team and the base permission in SOP-GOV-002.

Piece	What it is	Your organisation's address
Private room	`<org>/reading-room`: an **organisation-owned** private repository holding the drafts the organisation's people may read (proposals, procedures, decks). Its README is the index; PDFs sit beside the markdown	`https://github.com/<org>/reading-room`
Readers team	`<org>/<readers-team>` (for example `readers`), a closed team with **Read** on the private room and nothing else	`https://github.com/orgs/<org>/teams/<readers-team>`
Public room	`<org>/reading-room-public`: a public repository that receives **only allowlisted pages** from the private room, with a GitHub Pages front end in the house style	`https://<org>.github.io/reading-room-public/`
How drafts arrive	a sync workflow in the source (the `sync-public-allowlist.yml` shape: tripwire first, a deploy key per destination), never hand edits	the source repository's allowlist file

Why organisation-owned: a personal private repository cannot give anyone read-only access (the 422 below), and Pages on a private repository publishes **publicly** on the free plan, so a members-only website is not available today. The private room's front end is therefore the repository itself (README index, PDFs, decks); the public room is the website. A members-only site (an access gate in front of a Pages build, or GitHub Enterprise) is the later option.

ORG's reading room (filled in 2026-10-31, read again 2026-11-01)

Piece	ORG's address	State on 2026-11-01
Private room	https://github.com/Octagon-Religious-Research-Group-ORG/reading-room	**created**, private, merge commits only. README index; `proposals/`, `procedures/` and `decks/` shelves
Readers team	https://github.com/orgs/Octagon-Religious-Research-Group-ORG/teams/readers	**created**, closed, **Read** on `reading-room` and nothing else. Its only member is the steward who created it
Public room	https://github.com/Octagon-Religious-Research-Group-ORG/reading-room-public, served at https://octagon-religious-research-group-org.github.io/reading-room-public/	**created**, Pages on from `main`; its front end is one `index.html` in emerald, no build step

Procedures twin	https://github.com/Octagon-Religious-Research-Group-ORG/ops-standard-operating-procedures-public	**created**; README only until the first sync
How drafts arrive	the lab desk's `READING-ROOM-ALLOWLIST.txt` → `reading-room` (`READING_ROOM_DEPLOY_KEY`, in the lab desk); `reading-room`'s `PUBLIC-ALLOWLIST.txt` → `reading-room-public` (`READING_ROOM_PUBLIC_DEPLOY_KEY`); this repository's `PUBLIC-ALLOWLIST.txt` → the procedures twin (`SOP_PUBLIC_DEPLOY_KEY`)	**inert**: no deploy key exists yet. Each runs `scripts/allowlist-sync.sh`; the two public ones also run the public-lane tripwire (`scripts/scan-public-lane.sh`, SOP-OPS-003). Tripwire first, an ordinary commit, never a force-push

Base permission. Since 2026-11-01 ORG's base member permission is **No permission** (SOP-GOV-002). All four of ORG's members are owners today, so nobody lost access; the `readers` team becomes the door for the next person who joins as a member. Adding a reader, on an officer's yes:

```
gh api -X PUT orgs/Octagon-Religious-Research-Group-ORG/teams/readers/memberships/<login>
```

Steps: steward (once per organisation)

1. Create both rooms (an owner's action): `gh repo create <org>/reading-room --private` and `gh repo create <org>/reading-room-public --public`. *You should see:* both under the organisation's repositories.
2. Create the team and grant Read on the private room only:

   ```
   gh api -X POST orgs/<org>/teams -f name=<readers-team> -f privacy=closed
   gh api -X PUT orgs/<org>/teams/<readers-team>/repos/<org>/reading-room -f permission=pull
   ```

3. Add readers on an officer's yes: `gh api -X PUT orgs/<org>/teams/<readers-team>/memberships/<login>` (the same shape as SOP-GOV-001).
4. Give the public room a deletion-only ruleset (ORG's sync never force-pushes, and the ruleset keeps `main` from being deleted; SOP-OPS-002 legend) and turn on Pages from `main`.
5. Fill in the table above with the real addresses; link it from the organisation's `.github` README.

Steps: reader

1. Accept the organisation invitation and the team, then open the private room's README. *You should see:* the index, not a 404.
2. Read in the browser, or open a PDF from `pdf/`. To bring a helper, follow *bring a helper* above, choosing only `reading-room` in the token's repository selection.

Verification

The member opens the page from their own account; the helper's read test passes; the administrator can see the token under the organisation's personal access tokens with the expected scope.

Troubleshooting

Symptom	Likely cause	What to do
A read-only invitation to a personal (not organisation) private repository fails with 422	GitHub offers no read-only collaborator on personal repositories	use the organisation-owned repository as the door; never grant write and call it read-only
The token works for public repositories only	approval pending	the administrator approves it

The helper cannot reach a repository the member can	token's repository selection excludes it, or an outside-collaborator limitation	adjust selection, or move to organisation membership / an approved GitHub App

Related

- SOP-COM-001 *New to GitHub: your first hour* (where a newcomer starts), SOP-GOV-002 *GitHub collaboration*, SOP-OPS-003 *Private houses everything, public lanes witness*
- Proposal: THEF 012 *Your reading room, and how your helper joins you*
- `my-template/org-onboarding/ACCESS-AND-PATS.md`
- SOP-OPS-002 (a helper opens pull requests but does not merge; the legend), SOP-GOV-001 (the Board's room uses the same team shape)
- `my-template/workflow-templates/sync-public-allowlist.yml` (how drafts reach a room)

Change log

Date	Change	By
2026-10-30	Drafted from Littlebird's access draft and the Oct 30 verification	Alfred
2026-10-31	The generic reading-room route: an organisation-owned private room, a readers team with Read, a public room with a Pages front end, a fill-in address table	Alfred
2026-11-01	Lucid pass: Lucide icons, the route drawn in Mermaid; links to SOP-OPS-003 (the tripwires) and SOP-GOV-002 (teams, base permission none); new readers start at SOP-COM-001	Alfred
2026-11-01	ORG's copy brought level with my-template: Lucide icons in emerald, Mermaid where a picture explains, ORG's own facts kept; ORG's room table read again: both rooms and the twin created, base permission none, syncs inert until their keys	Alfred